

2 JAWAHARLAL NEHRU UNIVERSITY

Active Voices

The university continues to be a centre for out-of-the-box thinking

In 2008, a student of Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) was accused of bludgeoning a female dog to death. The brutality of the incident shocked the student community and triggered unanimous protests and signature campaigns against the accused. He was finally fined and thrown out of the hostel. In a country where many heinous crimes go unnoticed, few people outside the university could empathise with this agitation. But herein lies the essence of JNU, a university whose aim is to produce socially, culturally and environmentally responsible individuals.

Established in 1969, JNU's aim has been to inculcate academic excellence not just among the elite, but also the marginalised in the country. The university has produced some of the eminent politicians, bureaucrats, journalists and scientists in India. It continues to be one of the premier research institutes in Asia, where two-thirds of its student body is pursuing either M.Phil or Ph.D. It also played a pioneering role in interdisciplinary studies in India. Its School of Life Sciences, the first of its kind in the country, was conceptualised as an interdisciplinary integration of all biological sciences. The School of International Studies is the oldest in the country and was one of the first to develop multi-disciplinary expertise on different regions in the world. School of Environment Studies and School of Biotechnology attract some of the best minds in the country

and has several patents to its credit. The School of Language, Literature and Cultural Studies exposes students to almost all languages and literature of the world. "Our foreign language schools make use of information technology to provide the best pedagogy for students. Our graduates are highly sought-after in the industry and earn up to Rs 1 lakh per month," says B.B. Bhattacharya, vice-chancellor. Considering the tuition

order to facilitate faculty projects, science departments are offered Rs 10 lakh per project and humanities or social sciences departments receive Rs 4 lakh per project. There is no fixed curriculum in any subject. Every faculty member is encouraged to develop their own syllabus and bring in fresh and original ideas. Students are selected on their ability to innovate. "My research proposal received a lukewarm response in most universities as it is a new area in India. But at JNU, the reception was amazing," says Rukmini Pande, an M.Phil student of English who is working on cyber cultures and theories.

This out-of-the-box approach attracts students not only from India but all across the world. Its acceptance

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IN JNU, THERE IS A STRONG FOCUS ON POLITICAL AND SOCIAL AWARENESS

fee of Rs 12 per month, that certainly is a tremendous return on investment.

JNU does not offer any professional degrees and focuses on research in basic sciences and social studies. In

rate is one of the most competitive in the country. More than 1,12,000 students apply, but only 2,000 are selected. It has 350 students from outside India, representing 34 countries and the student-teacher ratio is 10:1.

Apart from its academics, JNU is renowned for its political vibrancy and social commitment. The rules of its Gender Sensitisation Committee against Sexual Harassment have now been adopted by many other institutes. "The campus is a safe zone. At no time of the day do we feel threatened," says Pande. Additionally, the 1,000-acre campus boasts of an impressive flora and fauna with nearly 154 species of birds alone.

by Diksha Madhok



"We plan to start a media research centre soon which would be first of its kind in the country. We will also offer post-graduate degrees in programmes such as women's studies and North-east studies."

B.B. BHATTACHARYA, vice-chancellor, Jawaharlal Nehru University